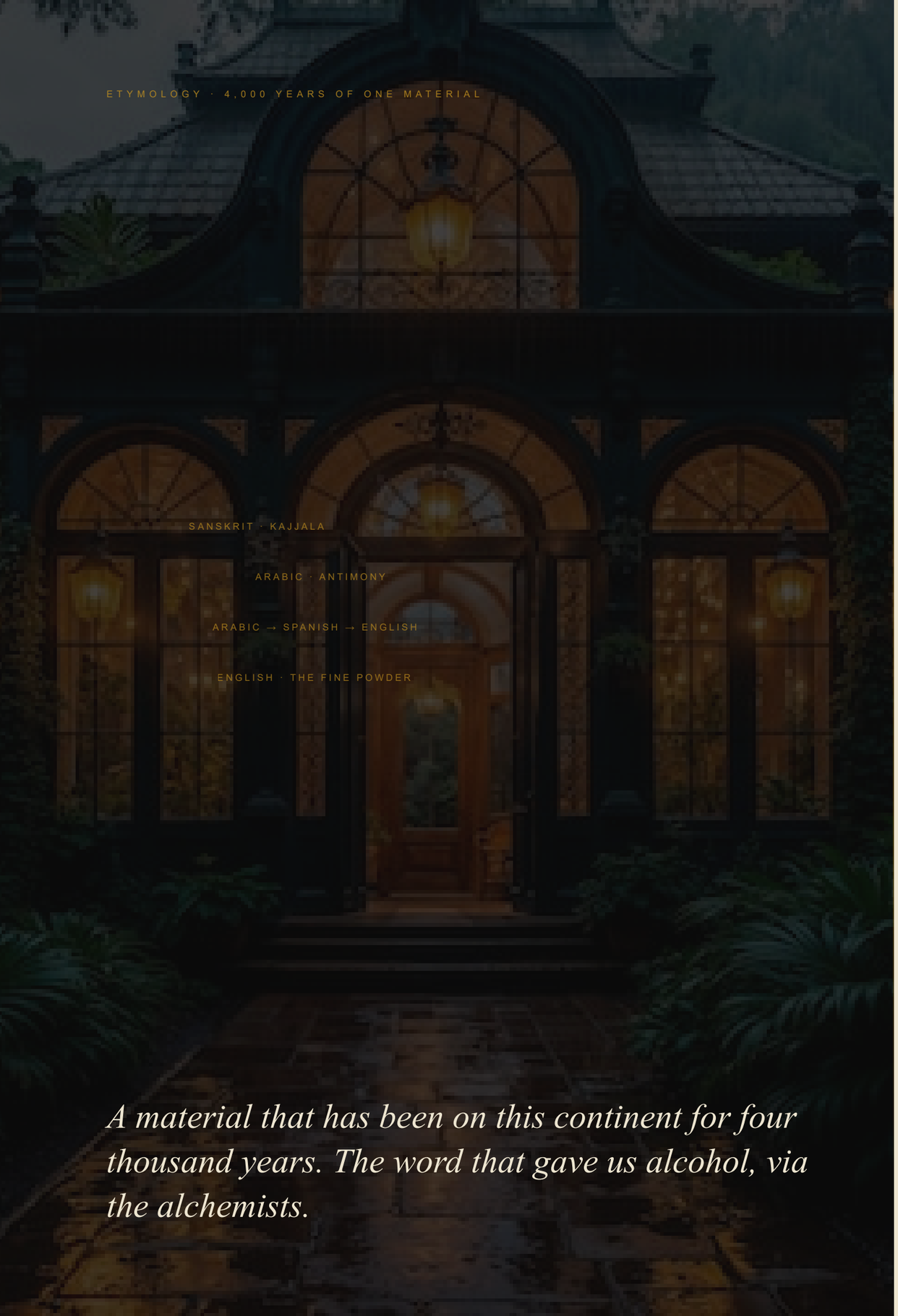
Kohl

كُحْل

Drawn from this ground.



ETYMOLOGY · 4,000 YEARS OF ONE MATERIAL

SANSKRIT · KAJJALA

ARABIC · ANTIMONY

ARABIC → SPANISH → ENGLISH

ENGLISH · THE FINE POWDER

A material that has been on this continent for four thousand years. The word that gave us alcohol, via the alchemists.

THE ARGUMENT

Kohl does not colour. It draws the outline that makes everything else visible.

Ground antimony sulphide mixed with oil, applied with a fine stick to the inner rim of the eye. Not pigment — definition. The darkest possible line against the lightest possible context. Kohl has been used in the Deccan plateau since before the cities that surround it were built. It predates the Kakatiya dynasty, the Bahmani Sultanate, the Qutb Shahis, and the Asaf Jahis. It predates Hyderabad by two thousand years.

The name was chosen for its properties, not its aesthetics: the ability to define presence without excess. The twelve villas at Kohl operate on the same principle. The architecture draws a line between private and public, between inside and outside, between the city's noise and a particular quality of quiet. It does not colour the landscape. It defines it.

The Deccan Synthesis

1347 – 1518

The Bahmani Sultanate

The first great synthesis on the Deccan Plateau — Persian administrative culture, Turkic military architecture, and local Dravidian craft traditions fused into a building language that belongs to nowhere else on earth. Wide courtyards, deep eaves for the plateau heat, water channels running through the centre of every major room.

Bidar, Gulbarga, Bijapur

1518 – 1687

The Qutb Shahis of Golconda

Founded Hyderabad in 1591. Built the Charminar, the Golconda Fort, the Mecca Masjid. Their architecture absorbs Indo-Persian influence and makes it coastal, humid, and pragmatic — arcaded walkways for shade, deep verandas, plaster ornamentation of extraordinary delicacy. The Golconda diamond mines funded half of the world's crowns.

Golconda Fort · Charminar · Mecca Masjid

1724 – 1948

The Asaf Jahi Nizams

The Nizams built on the synthesis — adding British colonial elements, Rajput courtly forms, and European engineering into an architecture that was cosmopolitan before cosmopolitan was a marketing term. The Falaknuma Palace (1884) combines Palladian façade with Deccan interior planning. The Purani Haveli's interior is six-hundred feet of private passage.

Falaknuma · Purani Haveli · Chowmahalla

PRESENT

Kohl at Jubilee Hills

Not pastiche — argument. The Deccan courtyard house typology offers a vernacular solution to Hyderabad's climate, social structure, and landscape. Wide overhangs. Central water. Inward-facing rooms around a protected core. Kohl does not quote these buildings. It inherits their logic and applies it to twelve contemporary households in the neighbourhood that most resembles their intent.

Prashashan Nagar · Jubilee Hills

حجر

Basalt & limestone

The Deccan Plateau is basalt — the same volcanic rock that forms the land beneath Jubilee Hills. Kohl's ground floor reads as this same material, honed dark. Limestone render above it. The building is made of what the site is made of.

خشب

Teak joinery

The haveli tradition of the Deccan used teak for all principal joinery — doors, screens, brackets. It ages. It oils. It develops a surface that no new material has. The pivot entry door at Kohl is solid teak, in this tradition — functional, heavy, permanent.

ماء

Water at centre

The zardozi fountain, the step-well, the courtyard channel: every major Deccan building had water at its centre for functional reasons. At Kohl, the private pool occupies the courtyard centre — evaporative cooling at the axis of the plan, not at the perimeter as decoration.

ظل

Deep overhangs

Hyderabad receives 1,400 hours of direct sun per year. The Deccan builders understood this: deep overhangs at 1.2–1.5m keep all glazing in shade from 10am–4pm in summer. Not a detail decision. A climate decision that also produces a specific aesthetic — the building hides from the afternoon sun, and looks better for it.

"The most distinctive buildings are those that were built for specific reasons, and those reasons show."

Every material at Kohl was chosen because it belongs to the Deccan Plateau. Not because it is expensive — because it is correct. The result is an architecture that does not need to explain its references. They are already under your feet.

PRASHASHAN NAGAR · JUBILEE HILLS · HYDERABAD

The neighbourhood that held its character while the city built itself around it.

Prashashan Nagar is the Jubilee Hills that existed before the tech corridor arrived. No through traffic, no commercial density, no incentive to change. The canopy of neem, peepal, and tamarind that covers the streets grew in during the 1970s and 1980s and has been left alone since — the same trees that would have shaded a Deccan haveli courtyard three centuries ago. Kohl occupies a specific piece of this ground, behind one gate, at a scale the neighbourhood can absorb without changing. Ten minutes from HITEC City. A different register entirely.

10'	0	40yr	XII
From HITEC City by car	Through traffic in the street	Established canopy. Native species.	Villas behind one gate.

THE DEVELOPER

SSquare
Est. 1991

Thirty-five years building Hyderabad's commercial infrastructure — over ten million square feet, privately held, privately financed. SSquare did not need to enter the residential market. They entered it once because this particular piece of land in this particular neighbourhood demanded to be built correctly — and they were the right people to do it.

Kohl is their first and only residential project. Three decades of material knowledge and construction rigour, applied to a building type they had never attempted before. The same discipline. The same standard. Applied to the place where twelve families will actually live.

"The Standard, Privately Held."

35

Years in commercial real estate

10M+

Square feet delivered

01

Residential project. This is it.

TWELVE PRIVATE VILLAS · JUBILEE HILLS · BY SSQUARE

Kohl

كُحْل

Drawn from this ground.